

Packing - Hanoi & Cat Ba

Fri 9 Oct to Sun 25 Oct 2026. Singapore layover, Hanoi, Cat Ba Island (climbing + deep water soloing), Hanoi again. Weather: roughly 22 - 30°C, humid, a chance of storms and rain.

Passport -valid, checked expiry -e-visa approved + a printed or saved copy	
Bags -main backpack (which one? carry-on only or checked?) -small daybag for Cat Ba days -dry bag / waterproof phone pouch for the boat and deep water solo days	
Climbing -climbing shoes -chalk bag and chalk -finger tape, skin balm -harness / helmet: <i>check what Cat Ba Climbing and the DWS operators supply before packing your own</i> -swimmers (2) -water shoes or grippy sandals for rocks and boats (optional) -quick-dry towel	
Toiletries -toothbrush -toothpaste -deodorant -sunscreen (reef-safe, Lan Ha Bay) -insect repellent -vegan soap / shampoo (travel size) -regular meds, plus a small first aid kit and blister plasters -motion-sickness tablets (boat and the Cat Ba bus/ferry transfer)	
Electronics -chargers -plug adapter (Vietnam is 220V, your Australian plugs won't fit) -converters, power-board -headphones -battery pack (carry-on only) -novels / downloads for the long flights and layover (do before leaving) -Grab app set up, Google Maps offline for Hanoi and Cat Ba	
Clothes - temp range about 22 - 30, humid, rain possible - you'll be sweaty, so quick-dry fabrics How often do you want to be washing? <i>Laundry is easy and cheap in Hanoi and Cat Ba, so once mid-trip is realistic. Pack for about 7 days.</i> - zip pants - 2 (one to climb in, one for travel) - shorts - 3 - shirts / t-shirts / quick-dry tops - 7 - long-sleeve sun shirt - 1 - light jumper or hoodie - 1 (planes, lounge, cooler nights) - one nicer outfit for the Hanoi days with your partner from the 22nd - coat? probably not	
Underwear and socks - about 8 days' worth	
Comfortable shoes (walking, plus sandals / thongs)	
Sleepwear / light trackies for downtime	
Hat, sunglasses	
Lightweight rain jacket (October storms)	
Snacks to bring (vegan, for the flights and the long Singapore night)	
Eye mask, earplugs, neck pillow (3:30am check-in, 6am flight)	
Some Vietnamese dong in cash (the Hanoi to Cat Ba transfer on the 12th is pay on arrival)	
Refillable water bottle (empty through security)	

Organising

Phone / data - sort out an eSIM for Vietnam? (check your phone supports eSIM; Singapore layover needs wifi or data too)

Bank - tell them you are going overseas (probably possible in your banking app). Check your card works abroad and what the foreign fees are.

Do you have copies of ID documents? - scans or copies, saved offline and emailed to yourself

Travel insurance - the tracker task is still open. Note World Nomads excludes deep water soloing on every plan, so buy a main policy for the rest, and ask the DWS operator for their cover terms in writing.

E-visa - confirm it is approved before flying.

Turn off home routines before leaving (tracker task)

Not booked yet: Hanoi stay for 20 - 25 Oct, and the Melbourne flight on 25 Oct

Travelling around

Getting to the airport on Fri 9 Oct - uber? Confirm time and who is driving.

Singapore layover (Fri 9 to Sat 10) - lounge booked (about 5 hrs); be at check-in/security about 3:30am for the 6am Hanoi flight. Free Changi City Sights tour or Jewel to fill the evening.

Getting from Hanoi airport to Urban Fragrance (Old Quarter) - Grab or a pre-booked transfer. *The 86 bus is the cheap option; check before relying on it.*

Mon 12 Oct - Hanoi to Cat Ba: transfer confirmed, pay on arrival. The 07:30 departure gets you climbing that afternoon. Free hotel pickup is usually Old Quarter only.

In Cat Ba - Bao Phuc Hotel (143 Tung Dinh) is about a 5 min walk to the centre. Cat Ba Climbing meets at 120 Nui Ngoc. DWS days: Wed 14 and Mon 19.

Tue 20 Oct - Cat Ba back to Hanoi: return transport not yet booked.

Sun 25 Oct - Hanoi airport to Melbourne: flight not yet booked; get to the airport via Grab.

Draft built from the itinerary and notes in the tracker plus general Hanoi/Cat Ba knowledge. Weather and quantities are estimates: adjust to suit you, and double-check what the climbing operators supply.